

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 17

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

- ROCK-CUT CAVES
- GUPTA PERIOD

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

EZHADIPPATTAM CAVES

CAVE NO. 3



“Cave of severe penance”

- 1 To the south at Sittanavasal , on the top of the hill there is a natural shelter known as **Eladipattam** (also **Ezhadippattam**). It served as a Jain shelter since 1st century BC.
- 2 Eladipattam is supposed to have got its name from **seven holes cut** in the rock- they serve as steps to ascend the shelter.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

EZHADIPPATTAM CAVES

CAVE NO. 3



Stone beds for Jain monks

3 Inside this cave there are **seventeen polished stone berths** aligned into rows, each with a raised part- most likely these were **beds for Jains with 'stone pillows'**.

4 The largest of these ascetic beds contains **inscription in Brahmi script, in Tamil language** from 1st century BC.

5 Some more inscriptions in Tamil language are from much later time- 8th century AD.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

EZHADIPPATTAM CAVES

CAVE NO. 3



Samavasarana painting- means “Refuge to All” a term for the divine preaching hall of the Tirthankara

6 These inscriptions name mendicants – monks who, most likely, spent their lives in insolation in this hill.

7 Sitannavasal, being the mirror of Jainism and the Jains' lifestyle, the paintings reflect the culture of the Jains. Unfortunately, most of these paintings have been either ruined by **bad weather or vandalised**.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

EZHADIPPATTAM CAVES

CAVE NO. 3

- 8 Eladipattam served as a site for very severe penance: **kayotsarga** (meditation in standing posture until salvation) and **sallekhana** (fasting until death).



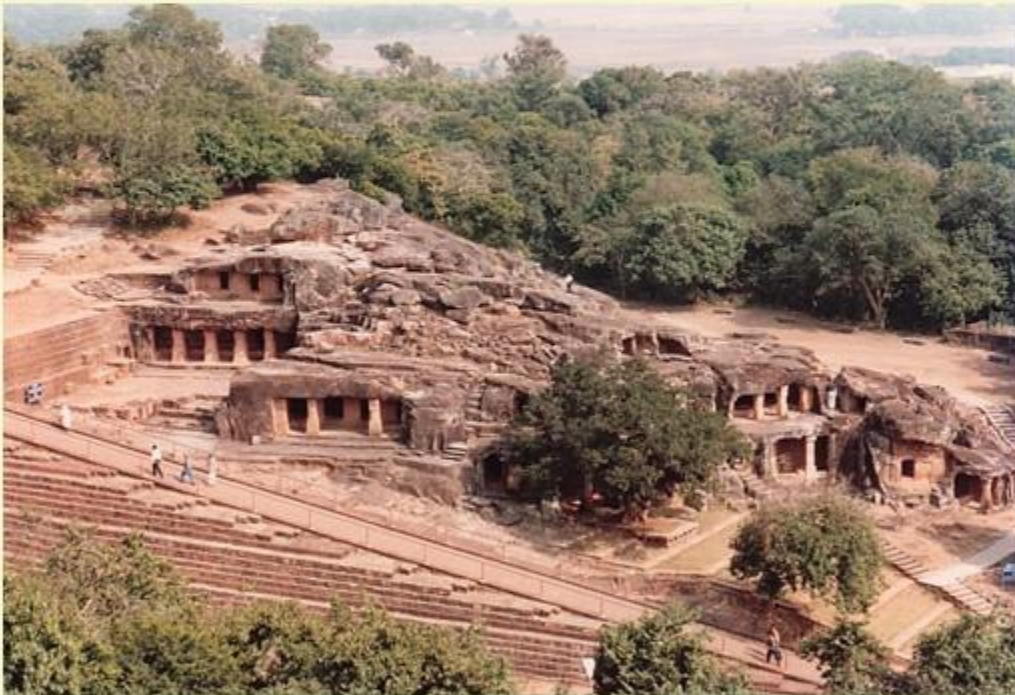
Figure left: Kayotsarga- to give up one's physical comfort and body movements thus remaining "steady".

Figure right- Sallekhana by Digambaras or Santhara by Svetambaras

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

UDAYAGIRI CAVES

CAVE NO. 4



- 1 At Udayagiri, 20 rock-cut chambers were excavated during the Gupta period, two of which bear inscriptions from the reign of Chandra Gupta II.
- 2 These caves are vital documents since they constitute some of the earliest intact body of Hindu art in India, and demonstrate that by the early fifth century , many Hindu iconographic formulas were already well established.
- 3 One of the most important caves at Udayagiri is Cave 5, the Varaha Cave

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

UDAYAGIRI CAVES

CAVE NO. 4



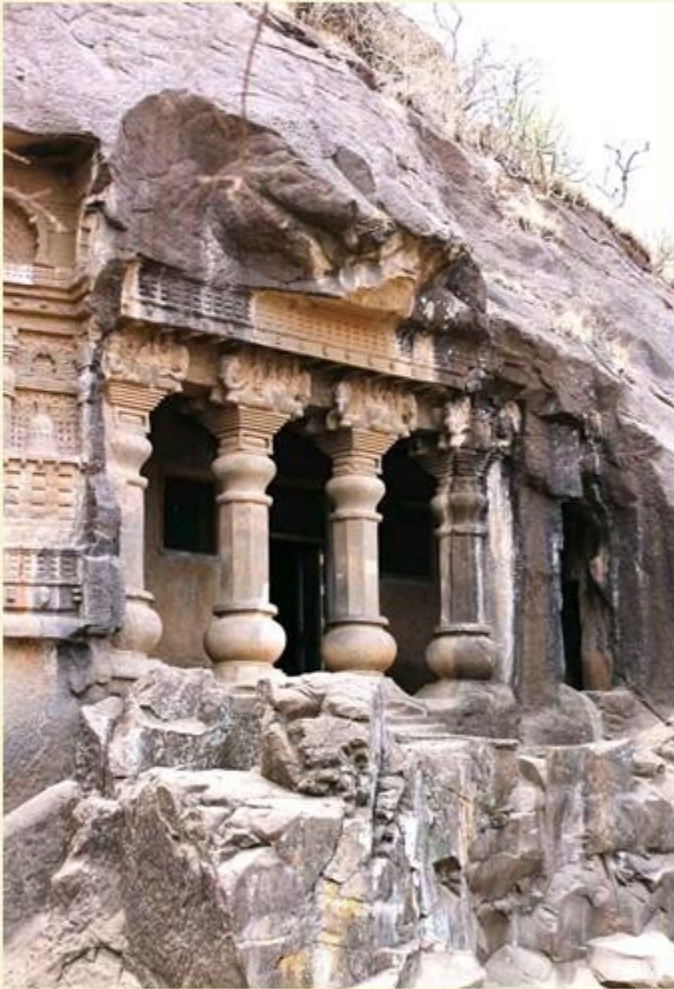
Varaha image in Udayagiri caves, Vidisha

- 4 Its main feature is a colossal rock-cut relief of the boar-incarnation (Varaha) of God Vishnu rescuing the Earth Goddess from chaos in the presence of adoring gods and saints.
- 5 The massive dynamism of the Varaha-god rises into gigantic appearance and is free from any restraint.
- 6 The power of the Indian artist reaches its peak in the well balanced composition of forceful energy combined with cosmic majesty, working for good against chaos and destruction.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

NASIK CAVES

CAVE NO. 5



- 1 To the south-west of Nasik, on the main Mumbai road, is an important group of 23 Buddhist caves belonging to the Hinayana period of Buddhist architecture and dating back to the 1st century AD.
- 2 So, there are no images of Buddha and his spiritual presence was denoted by a throne, a footstool, or footprints.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

NASIK CAVES

CAVE NO. 5



Pandavleni caves

3 This group of caves, is also called as **Pandu Lena**, is on the easternmost side of the three conical peaks at the extreme end of the **Trimbak range of hills**.

4 They consist of three large halls and one fine chapel.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

JUNAGADH CAVES

CAVE NO. 6



- 1 Located in Gujarat, a unique feature of the Junagadh caves is the presence of a 30-50ft high citadel known as “Upar Kot” in front of the prayer hall.
- 2 Uparkot (meaning ‘citadel’) is an ancient fortress which was the scene of historic sieges between the middle of the 14th and end of the 16th century AD.
- 3 Its entrance, in the form of an archway, is a fine specimen of the Hindu torana.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

JUNAGADH CAVES

CAVE NO. 6



4 Uparkot has many interesting Buddhist caves and was evidently the site of a Buddhist monastery in ancient times.

5 Some of the caves, apparently, were two or three storeys high.

6 Belonging to about AD300, their outstanding features are the halls, connected by winding staircases.

7 In the upper chamber is a small refractory and a tank surrounded by a corridor, all supported by six richly carved columns indicative of fine craftsmanship.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

UNDAVALLI CAVES

CAVE NO. 7

- 1 The Undavalli Caves near Vijayawada (Andhra Pradesh) are 7th century Hindu cave temples cut into many tiers along the slope of a back granite hill.



- 2 The main attraction is a reclining statue of Vishnu, sculpted from a single block of granite.



ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

ELEPHANTA CAVES

CAVE NO. 8



Trimurthi image

- 1 On the island of Elephanta, off the Mumbai harbor, are another great exquisite example of Rock-Cut Architecture which is also a **UNESCO World Heritage Site** known as the **Elephanta caves** of the 8th century AD.
- 2 The islands derive their name from the **giant carving of an elephant** which used to stand at the entrance.
- 3 The caves are believed to be **originally a Buddhist site** but later images are of **Shaivite faith**. The most famous are sculpture is the **Trimurti image**.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

ELEPHANTA CAVES

CAVE NO. 8



Trimurthi image

- 4 The masterpiece is a **three-faced image (Trimurti)** representing the **Maheswara aspect of Shiva**.
- 5 The left face presents the **fierce male aspect of Shiva**, the face on the middle is the meditative aspect of Shiva, the face on the right the gentle, feminine qualities of his all-transcending nature.
- 6 The other view is that the Trimurti represents **Brahma (creator), Vishnu (preserver) and Shiva (destroyer)**.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

ELEPHANTA CAVES

CAVE NO. 8



The stone elephant that gave the name Elephanta. It used to be on south shore of the island, the British attempted to move it to England in 1864, it broke, the reassembled pieces are now at the Jijamata Udyaan

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

ELEPHANTA CAVES

CAVE NO. 8



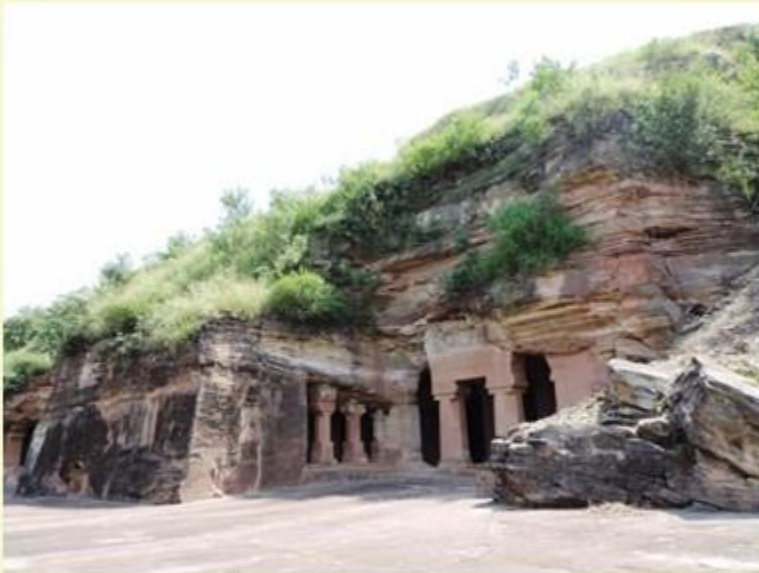
Ardhanariswara image

- 7 Other interesting sculptures in the cave show the marriage of Shiva with Parvati; Bhairava; Shiva in the tandava dance; Ravana, the demon king shaking Kailasa; Ardhanariswara- 'the Lord who is both male and female'.
- 8 The sculptures show slenderness with a unique light and dark effect. The caves are believed to be contemporary of Ellora.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

BAGH CAVES

CAVE NO. 9



1 In Bagh, Madhya Pradesh, there are **nine sandstone Buddhist caves with beautiful frescoes and sculptured stonework.**

2 A tentative dating assigns them to 6th century AD but they may have predated the Ajanta frescoes.

GUPTA PERIOD AND THEIR INFLUENCE ON ART AND CULTURE

- 1** The Gupta dynasty from 240 CE ushered in a new phase of growth and development in all walks of life.
- 2** Not only did areas of human knowledge like art, sculpture, science, technology, mathematics, astronomy, and philosophy flourish in this period but growth of agriculture, commerce, and trade coupled with sound administration and military conquests made it one of the most prominent regimes of its time in the world.
- 3** Eminent scholars and litterateurs like Kalidasa and Vishnu Sharma, astronomers, and scientists like Aryabhatta and Varahamihira, and other personalities like Vatsayana who made notable contributions in their respective fields, prospered in this age.
- 4** Historians have aptly termed it as a Golden Age of Indian history.

A BRIEF HISTORY OF THE GUPTA RULERS



Samudragupta playing veena

- 1 This empire was founded by **Srigupta**.
- 2 Chandragupta I, Samudragupta, and Chandragupta Vikramaditya (Chandragupta II) were the most notable rulers of this period.
- 3 Samudragupta who is known for his great military conquests is also referred by historians as the **Indian Napoleon**. He was himself a poet and musician (coins depict him playing a veena).

A BRIEF HISTORY OF THE GUPTA RULERS

4 The empire reached its zenith during Chandragupta II (375-415 CE) when a large part of the Indian subcontinent was directly under this empire or owed suzerainty to it.

5 A detailed account of the Gupta period is obtained in the writings of the Chinese traveller Faxian (also referred as Fahien) who stayed in India from 405 to 411 CE.

6 The accounts which are the most important source of information of this age, describe a prospering civilization, able but mild administration, and a glorious account of the rule and the king.

7 The Guptas were Hindu kings and Hindu art and culture underwent resurgence in this phase.

8 However, they were tolerant of Buddhism and Jainism and contributed to the development of a monastery at Bodhgaya.

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